

# Seychelles



Formerly a UK colony, the Seychelles comprises 115 islands in the Indian Ocean. After 14 years as a one-party state, multiparty elections were introduced in 1993.



## GEOGRAPHY

Mostly low-lying coral atolls, but 40, including the largest, Mahé, are mountainous and are the only granitic midocean islands in the world.



## CLIMATE

Tropical oceanic climate. Hot and humid. Rainy season December–May.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The islands were uninhabited when French settlers arrived in the 18th century. Today, the population is homogeneous – a result of inter-marriage between ethnic groups. Almost 90% of people live on Mahé. Living standards are among Africa's highest. Poverty is rare and the welfare system caters to all.

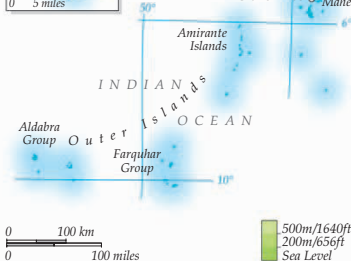


**INSIGHT:** The Seychelles' unique species include the coco-de-mer palm, which produces the world's largest seeds



## THE ECONOMY

Tourism is main sector, based on appeal of beaches and exotic wildlife. Tuna is fished and canned for export. Re-export trade. Virtually no mineral resources. All domestic requirements are imported. High debt-servicing burden. Lack of foreign exchange.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Seychelles

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1976

**CAPITAL:** Victoria

**POPULATION:** 84,600

**TOTAL AREA:** 176 sq. miles  
(455 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 813 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Creole\*, English\*, French\*

**RELIGIONS:** Roman Catholic 90%, Anglican 8%, other (including Muslim) 2%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Creole 89%, Indian 5%, other 4%, Chinese 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Seychelles rupee = 100 cents